

environment KERALA

GOD'S DISOWNED

Crass commercialisation on its golden beaches and placid backwaters, with little concern for the environment, may make Indian tourism's biggest success story a victim of its own windfall

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Ever since he turned a teenager, it had been Pierre Gagne's dream to visit Kerala. He had read it all in *National Geographic Traveller*, *Conde Nast* and countless other magazines about the place that was described as among "50 must see destinations of a lifetime". Last week, the 20-year-old from Paris arrived in Thiruvananthapuram to find that "God's own country" was more like a monument to good intentions going terribly awry.

Streets in the main cities resemble garbage dumps, which even led to the outbreak of chikungunya—an epidemic which killed more than 200 persons in the state in the past two years. The roads are horrible enough for the state high court to severely reprimand the Government for "having the worst roads in the world". The state, which invented the concept of eco-tourism, is now witnessing large-scale devastation of environment at its famed beaches, backwaters and hills. At the Kovalam beach, which draws lakhs of tourists every year from around the world, Gagne saw a huge concrete pipe spewing sewage water into the sea from the many hotels and restaurants on the

PARADISE LOST: Kovalam's beach front (right); dirt in the backyard



FROM BAD TO WORSE

A study by Greenpeace and an NGO Thanal in 2003 gave details of the daily flow of waste at Kovalam

Biodegradables: 6.7 tonne
Plastic mineral water bottles: 6,098
Plastic bags: 1,464
Milk sachets: 2,762
Paper waste: 135 kg
Plastic cups: 720

Things are now said to be much worse.

